



50 32 Laptops Tested!



77 Tips: Outlook, Linux, Torrent Clients



85 Pixel-perfect

Digital Tools

Technology For Personal And SoHo Productivity

Lead Feature

Hacking The Kid

Kids have this annoying habit of getting stuck to PCs—why not make sure they learn something while they're at it?

Nimish Chandiramani

It's not like we have a foot in the grave here or anything, but every once in a while, today's kids make us feel old—learning how to configure your mobile phone from a 12-year old doesn't really help that youthful feeling. With a PC in nearly every middle class home, and more on the way, it's no surprise that parents summon the off-spring every time an error message baffles them. The kids will be exposed to technology no matter how much you "protect" them from it—even if you don't buy a PC; the best you can do is ensure they're using applications that will be of some use to them.

EasyBits Magic Desktop

www.easybits.com

Remember Microsoft Bob? In the days of Windows 3.1, Bob was a new, friendly user interface for Windows, designed to make computers easy to use for newcomers. A little dog named Rover guided you around the OS, telling you what you could do with it. The idea was nice, but Bob was a little too friendly and quite an insult to the intelligence, and finally made it to the Dark Place where all terrible products end up. When we first started up Magic Desktop from this

month's DVD, it reminded us of Bob, only without the nausea.

Somehow, it's taken someone this long to realise that the same idea could apply wonderfully to children—Magic Desktop looks like Windows XP, only with child-friendly colours, themes and applications—perfect to keep a 5 to 10-year-old off your back. It functions like a protective layer on your XP installation, blocking keyboard shortcuts like [Alt] + [Tab] and [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Del], and suppressing applications and dialogs that may pop up in the background—ensuring that your child doesn't stray into your running applications and do some damage. You're also given full control over Internet access—the bundled browser will load Web sites only after you approve them. The bundled applications range from simple maths quizzes to puzzle games, and even a child-friendly e-mail client! While Magic Desktop insulates your child from everything else on your PC, you can decide which applications can be accessed from within Magic Desktop.



Magic Desktop's music player lets your child go wild—just make sure to turn down the volume

Illustration Chaitanya Surpur
Photograph Sandeep Patil